“If you gathered in one room all the former IDF chiefs of staff, the Shin Bet’s directors, the heads of military intelligences, and the directors of the Mossad, 90 per cent of them would tell you that it is way simpler to defend Israel from within borders that reflect its security interests, with a solid Jewish majority for generations, alongside a Palestinian state, than to defend ‘one Jewish state’ stretching from the Jordan River to the sea, with millions of Palestinians within its borders,” Barak said in his speech.

Benny Gantz, the recently-retired chief of staff, made a similar point a few months earlier, at a conference of the Institute for National Security Studies. He told the audience that Israel’s greatest long-term threats were inequality and the educational system, not security. And he argued in favor of a renewed diplomatic push with the Palestinians. “Even if it fails, and we’ll need to continue to live by the sword, we need to be able to look at our kids in the eyes and tell them we tried,” he said.

An army that had a country

Lieberman’s first few months as defense minister were wholly uneventful. Israel didn’t bomb the Aswan High Dam or invade Gaza City. He stopped commenting publicly on Elor Azaria, who by then was on trial for manslaughter. When it came time to implement a Supreme Court ruling and demolish Amona, an illegal outpost in the occupied West Bank, Lieberman was one of the few right-wing voices to support Netanyahu (which will be discussed later in the book). Unlike Bennett, he didn’t react with glee to Trump’s election as president. None of this was a great surprise: even opponents have described him to me as “the most pragmatic politician in Israel.” And that was the point. By installing a hardheaded right-wing politician in the defense ministry, Netanyahu made it harder for the traditionally centrist security establishment to act as a countervailing force.

Demographic trends also tilt in his favor, as the *kibbutzniks* no longer play such an outsized role in the Israeli army. They have been eclipsed by soldiers from the national-religious community. A study by *Ma’arachot*, the defense ministry’s official journal, found that they accounted for 26 per cent of the officer corps in 2008, up from just 2.5 per cent in the 1990s. That number will continue to rise: according to some researchers, more than one-third of army cadets now hail from the *dati-leumi* sector.